Malhar, Kaushambi, and Champa, to name a few that were fairly prosperous: the material evidence of archaeology and documentary sources suggest this. However, these urban agglomerations were not the spots chosen for inscriptions. Ashoka's earliest message was engraved mainly in the hills, in rock shelters, and on prominent rocks in the vicinity of locally significant places. Whether he wanted his words to be engraved in such places and not in the premier cities of his empire, he doesn't tell us. So, let us turn to the places he chose, or which happened to be chosen by his officials, to try and see why such places were picked.

Maski in Karnataka is one of these. Maski is the modern name, after a village there which either got its name from or gave its name to the Maski nullah, a tributary of the Tungabhadra river that flows nearby. In the third century BCE, not far from present-day Maski, was a settlement in the south-east of the hill now known as Durgada Gudda, that being the most conspicuous hill alignment to be found here. The settlement today is only recognizable from large quantities of potsherds that litter the soil where cultivated fields of cotton and sunflower now stand. But a few thousand years ago, in the time of Ashoka, a copper- and iron-using culture flourished at the spot.

From finds that emerged out of excavations conducted at Maski in 1954, we learn how some of the subjects of the Mauryan emperor lived in this part of Karnataka. This was a sedentary agricultural society which reared cattle and goats.[34] While the houses have not survived, we know that timber was used in their building since post holes—in which originally were wooden poles that have decayed without a trace—have been seen and these must have supported the frame for thatched roofs. The habitations have more or less disappeared, but the burial practices of these people have survived a little. That the burials and habitation were contemporaneous is evident from the fact that there is an identity in the kind of pottery found in both deposits. Several of the burials were within the habitation area itself.